

V . S . N A I P A U L



THE PROVOCATEUR

In a literary career spanning half a century and 29 genre-defying books, the mercilessly truthful traveller has never failed to astonish with the intensity of his intellect. Now comes another shocker.

■ By S. Prasannarajan

Romantic and beautiful though the idea is," writes V.S. Naipaul in his new book, "there is no such thing as a republic of letters where—as in an anti-chamber to a fairly judged after-life of reputation or neglect, and in the presence of a literary St Peter—all bring their work and all are equal. That idea of equality is of course false." That is why there is this singular force called Naipaul, a traveller who argues his way through the treacherous alleys of half-made societies, a storyteller whose imagination is inseparable from the wreckage of history. In a literary career spanning 50 years and 29 genre-defying books (he published his first novel when he was 25), he has shown a terrifying passion for truth, which is merciless, like the opening sentence of his novel *A Bend in the River*: "The world is what it is; men who are nothing, who allow themselves to become nothing, have no place in it." As provocateur and prophet, he consistently challenges the received wisdom of the times. As stylist and observer, he remains unassailable in English prose. Sir Vidiadhar Surajprasad Naipaul never ceases to astonish—with the intensity of his intellect, with the Englishness of his detachment, with the freedom of a wayfarer who doesn't have "a past that is available to me, a past I can enter into and consider" but whose travels in the vandalised past of others have become some of the finest interventions in literature.

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Three years ago, we thought the traveller was on retreat. The setting was poignantly Indian, as if he was at the end of an extended ancestral rite. After famously declaring a few years ago the demise of the much-exhausted novel, he had staged a remarkable comeback. *Half A Life* (2001) was his first Indian novel, and three years later came not a sequel but an extension of it, *Magic Seeds*. There he was, with India on his mind—the India that was once a great hurt, and from whose poverty his grandfathers had had to run away. He had overcome; he had gone past the angry indictment of *An Area of Darkness* (1964), the disillusion of *A Wounded Civilization* (1977), and the rather compassionate engagement of *India: A Million Mutinies Now* (1990). "I can't reject India. It is going too fast, even beyond me. I'm sitting back and feeling quite happy actually," he told INDIA TODAY on the eve of the publication of *Magic Seeds*. (You could spot the great man in tweeds

enjoying a quiet drink with his wife Lady Nadira Naipaul in the bar of a Delhi hotel very often nowadays—India has become his second home.) Then, towards the end of the conversation, he paused, and said in that trademark upper-class English stutter, "I'm quite old, you know. I'm not in the best of shape, and you have to be very well to write another book. At this moment, this is my last book."

Well, the world is still too much of a whirl to keep Naipaul as a retired writer, or as prophet at rest, in his private hermitage in the English countryside of Wiltshire. His new